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Global Tech Headlines | 16 October 2026

Five original English headlines with direct publisher links and exact source excerpts.

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01 · GLOBAL TECH NEWS

Googlebook review: Android on a laptop is still Android

Ars Technica · 2026-10-16

Android was designed for phones, but that hasn’t stopped Google from trying to adapt the OS and its apps to larger machines over the years. Googlebooks are just the latest attempt after tablets, Chromebooks, and foldables induced little change in how people interact with Android software. These new Android-powered laptops are designed to pick up where the web-focused ChromeOS left off, offering premium hardware and native support for Android apps.

Google sees Googlebooks as an alternative to Windows and macOS, but these platforms are entrenched with decades of software and UI conventions that keep users locked in. Googlebooks have to offer something very special to steal users away from either of the dominant operating systems.

For devoted Android phone users, there are some cool things in Googlebook OS, but the Android roots of these machines are impossible to miss. Sometimes it feels like using a Chromebook, and sometimes it feels like using a giant phone. It almost never feels like using a premium laptop, and that’s the problem.

Source: https://arstechnica.com/reviews/2026/10/googlebook-review-android-on-a-laptop-is-still-android

02 · GLOBAL TECH NEWS

A week with RTX Spark: everything we've learned using Nvidia's new laptops

The Verge · 2026-10-16

Nvidia's RTX Spark N1X processor is finally here, and we've been collectively testing a small fortune's worth of powerful laptops sporting this new "superchip." RTX Spark is designed to be a high-performing Arm-based SoC for laptops and small desktop computers, rivaling the best from Apple, Intel, AMD, and Qualcomm. It has loads of cores, Nvidia RTX Blackwell graphics, and enough power and unified memory to run sizable local AI models.

The flagship placement is inside Microsoft's Surface Laptop Ultra with a staggering 128GB of unified memory, which our own Tom Warren fully reviewed . Sean Hollister has been testing a 64GB version of the Asus ProArt P16, which I've also been testing in its top-spec 128GB config. Since I'm the most spoiled of the lot, I also have a 64GB Lenovo Yoga 9n 2-in-1 and a 32GB HP OmniBook Ultra in for testing.

All of these laptops have the same N1X chip with 20 CPU cores and 6,144 GPU CUDA cores, and they're all wildly expensive — ranging from the HP OmniBook at $3,199.99 to the Asus ProArt's $6,999.99. There's an 18-core / 5,120 CUDA N1X chip in lower cost configs, but that only gets as cheap as $2,599.99 for a Surface Laptop Ultra or a smaller Asus ProArt P14 with 24GB of RAM.

Source: https://theverge.com/tech/1012748/nvidia-rtx-spark-windows-arm-laptops-asus-hp-lenovo-impressions

03 · GLOBAL TECH NEWS

Trump’s AI task force starts work and tells labs to report rogue behaviour

The Next Web · 2026-10-16

Jay Clayton’s official portrait as US director of national intelligence, August 2026.

“Our message to all SI companies is clear: delayed notification, inadequate corrective action, and a failure to take responsibility will not be tolerated,” the task force’s leaders said.

Jay Clayton, Andrew Ferguson, Scott Kupor and Emil Michael lead Donald Trump’s Super Intelligence Force. They sent that warning to AI companies this week. On Thursday, the task force held its first official meeting and formally adopted its charter, Semafor reported. That starts a 120-day window to settle how the government should handle the technology.

Clayton called the meeting “very good” on CNBC’s Squawk Box on Friday. He said it built on the accord Trump signed with AI leaders last month, which Trump has called “morally binding”.

The task force agreed to commission a report on AI risk from the President’s science advisers. It will cover three areas. They are cybersecurity and critical infrastructure, biosecurity and dual-use applications, and “model control and accountability”.

Source: https://thenextweb.com/news/super-intelligence-force-charter-first-meeting-anthropic

04 · SILICON VALLEY

Tressfecta wants to make hair braiding a less arduous task for hairstylists

TechCrunch · 2026-10-16

Aisata Diallo, 24, calls herself a lifelong braider. “I’ve always braided my hair growing up and, at some point in my college career, started braiding other people’s hair,” she said. At Northeastern University in Boston, she found limited access to braiders and textured-hair specialists, so she decided to fill that gap by starting a small business of her own.

“Throughout that experience, I was very close to some of the pain points in the styling process and complained about it constantly,” she said. Braiding is a manual task, and a single style can take eight hours to complete. Many professionals deal with issues like cramping and carpal tunnel syndrome after spending long days standing behind a chair weaving hair into patterns.

At first, Diallo said she didn’t know what to do about it. “I stopped braiding, and one of the reasons that I stopped braiding was due to the physical toll it has on your body.” She wanted to find a way to make braiding less painful and wondered whether new AI technology could automate some part of the process. Building hardware for braiding is expensive, difficult, and complex, which is one reason there have been few innovations in this space.

Source: https://techcrunch.com/2026/10/16/tressfecta-wants-to-make-hair-braiding-a-less-arduous-task-for-hairstylists

05 · THINK TANK WATCH

Offshore forwards and exchange rate transmission in emerging markets

Bank for International Settlements · 2026-10-16

Offshore Forwards and Exchange Rate
Transmission in Emerging Markets ∗
Gerardo Ferrara Andreas Schrimpf
Bank of England Bank for International Settlements & CEPR
Ganesh Viswanath-Natraj Zijie Wang
Warwick Business School Warwick Business School
This version: 7th October 2026
Abstract
We study how offshore non-deliverable forward (NDF) markets transmit exchange-rate pressures to domestic currency markets.

Using unique transaction-level data on the universe of centrally cleared NDFs for ten emerging-market currencies over 2013–2025, we show that offshore NDF order flow moves both offshore forward and domestic spot exchange rates and widens the offshore–onshore forward spread. To our knowledge, this is the first transaction-level evidence on price formation in these markets.

A $1 billion long-USD order flow depreciates the domestic spot rate by about 10 basis points and the offshore NDF rate by about 18 basis points. The spot impact is larger when dealer balance sheets are tight. Policy episodes in the Chinese renminbi, Malaysian ringgit, and Indian rupee show how changes in offshore speculative activity and arbitrage between offshore and onshore markets affect the spread and domestic exchange rates.

Source: https://bis.org/publications/working-paper-1383-offshore-forwards-and-exchange-rate-transmission-emerging-markets.pdf

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